

Handle With Care

Your paper resume isn't the only thing potential employers are looking at. Your life, your friends, your hobbies—if it's on the Web, they can see it

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What do most of us do when we fire up our browsers first thing in the morning? Chances are, apart from checking e-mail, we log in to social networking sites to check up on friends and acquaintances. This trend is more noticeable with the current generation of professionals, many of whom believe that e-mail is so last century. If you are in the age group of 15-30, when was the last time you had e-mailed a colleague

to enquire whether he or she would be there at the office party this Friday?

As places to hang out, have fun and meet people from all over the world these Web sites are the online equivalent of the office water-cooler. Most of them offer features like writing short messages to friends, uploading pictures and videos and projecting a unique identity by customising profiles. Still other sites focus exclusively on sharing photos and videos, and thereby aim at creating a community. In fact, we've covered these sites exhaustively in our *Fast Track To The Social Web*. What we haven't

talked about is their impact on individuals, and the feeling of freedom they grant us. For every LinkedIn that could get you a job, there's an Orkut that could result in your losing it.

Responsible Behaviour

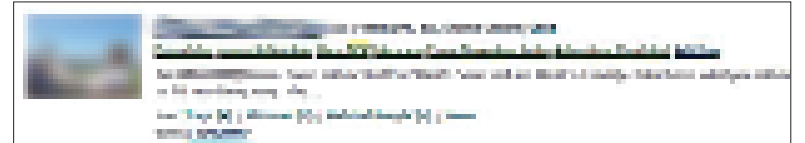
With that freedom—to paraphrase the Indian Constitution—comes responsibility. And for a change, this responsibility is not towards society or the country—it's towards you. In the *laissez faire* world of social networking, it's almost too easy to go astray. With the absence of any accountability or the need to face people personally, users are tempted to spice up their profiles and adopt a completely different persona. Peer pressure also adds a lot to this multiple personality syndrome: after all, we all want to look great and have more friends or messages from the opposite sex. And if those people are good looking, you are guaranteed to be the talk of the campus and the heart of the party. In fact, there are sites where you can hire models to be in your friend profile: they will also message or scrap you with sentences that don't look like they have been spewed by a chat bot. Choices are yours—the sky is the limit. You might even become an Internet celebrity based on a YouTube video: a case in point is Lonelygirl15, a "teenager" who posted a series of videos where she talks about her lonely life, and which were followed by millions of people as avidly as they would follow a blockbuster TV show. That she was later revealed to be an actress and those videos were professionally shot is another matter.

The point is that people can draw erroneous conclusions based on your online presence—they say that on the Internet, a dog could be a man, and nobody would know. The reverse is also unfortunately true. The Web is a biased judge, jury and executioner all rolled into one. For example, not so long ago the gruesome pictures of Nicole Castouras, a young girl killed in a high speed crash were leaked by officers of the California Highway Patrol. Those pictures eventually appeared in more than 1600 Web sites and made life hell for the Castouras family, who had to repeatedly endure the sick photographs of their daughter's decapitated body posted on these sites and also mailed to them, some accompanied by comments which insinuated that she got what she deserved.

Many A Slip

It doesn't take gruesome accident pictures to ruin your reputation and peace of mind. Your Orkut profile is just as effective. Think about it: while you are in the race to impress your peers by snagging the most number of female friends and updating fake photos which show you off as über-cool, there are some other people out there that would possibly take a dim view of this whole scenario. One group is your family; another group is potential and present employers. For the purpose of this article, let's focus on the latter.

By default, profiles, photos, videos and such other badges of identity in most networks is public. They have to be—there is no point in



We'd guess you don't want your boss to see this

First impressions are incredibly hard to dispel, and "sensitive" keywords always raise warning flags in minds of prospective employers and partners

slaving over your profile and leaving it to be seen by three friends. But there is a downside to all the attention-mongering: you can be searched for just as easily by people from whom you'd prefer to not know that side of your personality. Search engines accomplish this in seconds with a few carefully chosen keywords. General search engines like Google, as well as people search engines like Spock—which specifically crawl most social sites—throw up profile photos, interests, books you read, movies you saw and a hundred other details. Oh, and another thing: Google caches Web results for years. If you had led a wild life which was reflected in your older MySpace profile and posted a few NSFW (Not Safe For Work) photos, be assured that someone will still be able to access it even after you became respectable and deleted them.

Since it is always better to show than talk, we fired up Spock. Here you can search for persons by name and/or e-mail ID, while more advanced search options let you narrow down the search by age, sex, location, tags and picture. We entered a few sufficiently generic names—we won't mention the—and entered the tag "sex". A second later, the whole page was full of profiles where the "sex" word was either in a TV show or in the name of a movie or a book they recently saw or read. Later in the page, we hit paydirt: people who've put "likes sex" (along with books, movies and what not) on their profiles. Oops! While we won't be judgemental, and wish them the best of luck, we can bet that when any of them walks into a room with a Web 2.0-savvy interviewer, their applications will be looked at with at least one raised eyebrow.

Employees In Sights

That's actually sad, because many of them might have made those profiles just for fun. But first impressions are incredibly hard to dispel and such keywords always raise warning flags in minds of prospective employers and partners. Videos and photographs can also get out of hand pretty fast and become viral. While job oriented Web sites allow candidates to post video resumes of themselves, putting irrelevant material there would risk your present and future job prospects, especially if it showed off your tap dancing skills with a half naked partner, and if it ever got popular on YouTube. As a candidate, we always research prospective employers, looking not only at financial reports but also how good the work environment is. It stands to reason that employers would also check not only our academic background, but also our social background as reflected in such sites. As Ulhas Aher, HR Head of Datacraft—a unified com-

